



enjoyed the experience of staying in the Olympics village. I remember getting tense about finding my way back to my apartment, as all of them looked similar. And by the time I reached there, I often found that the Indian food was no longer available.

It was not just the Indians, athletes from other countries also would come to enjoy our food. So I would have to eat something that I was not used to and as a result I had an upset stomach on a few occasions. **The most abiding memory from the village at the Los Angeles Olympics also has got something to do with food.** My entry to the 400 hurdles final had attracted the attention of foreign athletes and coaches as well.

One of those coaches — I think he was French — came up to me

and asked me what the secret of my sprint was. I told him jokingly that the secret was the tender mango pickle that I had brought from home. So he ate the pickle along with some rice.

Being European, his stomach couldn't bear such Indian spice and I remember him running around the dining hall in great discomfort. He had to eat curd and icecream to lessen the effect of the pickle. After that, whenever we met, he would tell me that the secret of my sprint was indeed remarkable.

Another thing that I remember from Los Angeles is my surprising recovery from a knee injury. The hydrotherapy using a cycle suggested by a physiotherapist there proved miraculous for me. My pain — one that troubled me for a long time — was gone in just two

days. It was a big relief mentally, too: I felt free after the pain went away. That also made me realise the kind of facilities foreign athletes had. We had not even heard of something like that in India then.

**I consider myself fortunate that I could be part of so many Olympics. It is gratifying to note that I am going through the whole cycle as an athlete at the Olympics.**

I began my Olympic journey in Moscow as a teenager whose only aim was not to finish last in her races, and I didn't. I went as a coach, as an observer and now as an administrator. As the IOA president, I am happy that I have been able to make a difference to our athletes in their preparations. And I believe we can improve on our fine show in Tokyo.

**As told to P. K. Ajith Kumar**